

faith. Dowland was downhearted at this and, leaving his family behind in England, he decided to seek his fortune abroad.

Dowland's travels took him to princely courts in Germany and Italy, where he was received enthusiastically and showered with expensive gifts to send to his wife—a gold chain and clothing from the duke of Brunswick; a gold ring and cup from the landgrave of Hesse. In Italy, though, he ran into a group of disaffected Catholics, who seemed to be plotting against Elizabeth I (see box). Dowland immediately took fright. He wrote a long, rambling letter to Robert Cecil, the secretary of state, assuring him of his loyalty to Elizabeth and offering his services as a spy. What the authorities made of this somewhat paranoid missive is not recorded, but it certainly did not help Dowland's job prospects.

He returned to England in 1597, still hoping for royal preferment, but once again he was overlooked. Dowland profited from the visit, however, by publishing his groundbreaking collection, *The Firste Booke of Songes or Ayres*. This proved hugely popular, in part because of its ingenious “table layout,” which enabled musicians or singers to stand around a small table and read their parts from a single text.



ELSINORE, DENMARK, c. 1600